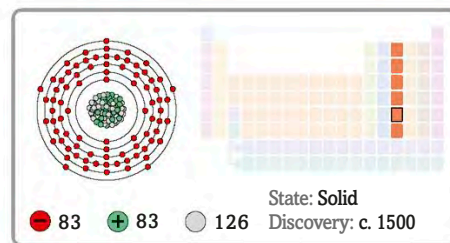


83

Bi

Bismuth



Forms

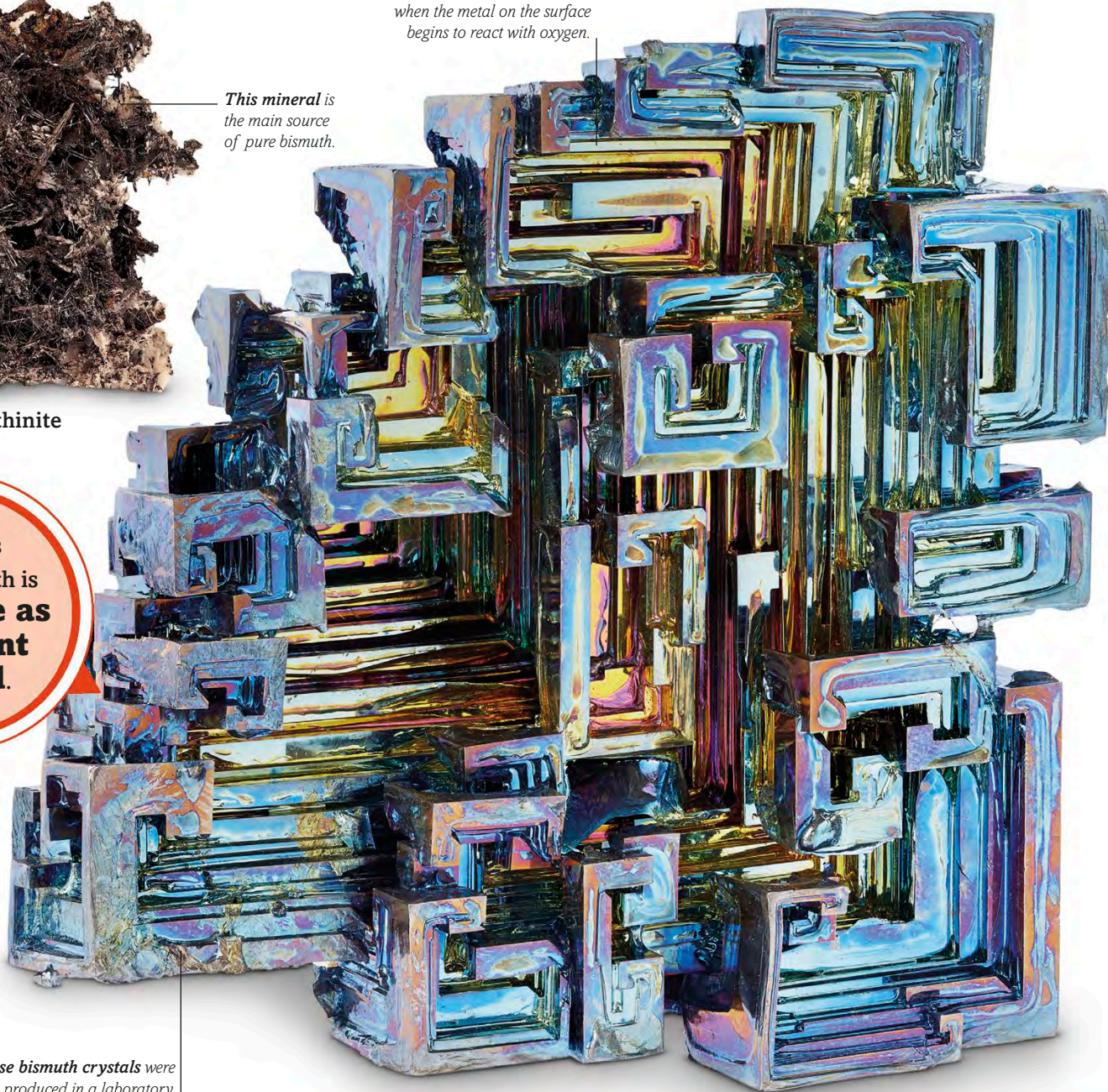


Bismuthinite

This mineral is the main source of pure bismuth.

These rainbow colours form when the metal on the surface begins to react with oxygen.

Hopper crystals refined in a laboratory



These bismuth crystals were produced in a laboratory.

In Earth's crust, bismuth is about **twice as abundant as gold**.

Bismuth is a radioactive element but its atoms are relatively stable and last for millions of years. People have known about bismuth for centuries. The Incas of South America added it to weapons made of the alloy bronze to harden them, while

ancient Egyptians used a bismuth mineral to make their cosmetics glittery. Pure bismuth forms an oxide in air that is seen as colourful crystals called **hopper crystals**. This element is very brittle and has few uses when not in a compound form. Yellow bismuth